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Managing Diversity and Inclusion

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Learning Objectives

After studying this chapter, you should be able to:

- **Define** the differences between diversity and inclusion
- **Evaluate** a range of different approaches to diversity used by organisations
- **Critically** assess the theoretical principles underlying the practice of equality, diversity and inclusion
- **Evaluate** the challenges that firms face in seeking to apply diversity and inclusion strategies in a global context

Introduction

Managing diversity is now seen as a fundamental part of mainstream HR practice. A focus on diversity recognises that our workforces differ in a variety of ways. Examples include gender, ethnicity, age, sexuality, religion, disability and social status. Managing diversity encompasses numerous concepts and refers to the systematic and planned commitment on the part of organisations to recruit and retain employees from diverse demographic backgrounds (Thomas, 1992). Building on the notion that all differences between groups and individuals within organisations should be recognised and valued, managing diversity presents a business case for equal opportunities. In linking

individual employee differences and equal opportunities initiatives directly with business strategy, the concept of managing diversity is inextricably linked to strategic HRM, and therefore a focus for the HR practitioner (Shen et al., 2009).

This chapter outlines the principles behind the managing diversity approach and examines some key issues in diversity debates. The chapter begins by outlining the context in which managing diversity has arisen. The principles of managing diversity strategies are then discussed, together with some managerial techniques and tools. The international and cultural contexts of diversity strategies are then considered, jointly with the challenges facing the creation of global diversity programmes. The chapter concludes by examining some of the key issues and debates. These include a consideration of the effectiveness of managing diversity initiatives, a critique of the business case rationale for managing diversity initiatives and the move towards inclusion to address issues of fairness and equality in the workplace. We also consider theoretical developments, such as intersectionality, which impact how diversity is understood.

Managing Diversity and Inclusion: A Brief History

Diversity management first emerged within the 1980s US business literature, due mainly to two important contextual catalysts: changing demographic trends and the business case for the progression of equal opportunities.

Demographic Trends

The development of managing diversity strategies is clearly located within the context of shifting demographic trends, with workforce diversity increasing since the term was first coined. The significant demographic trends witnessed in North America, namely, increasing numbers of women and ethnic minorities – groups traditionally disadvantaged in the employment market – now entering the workforce, and an increase in the overall age of the working population, were also predicted throughout Europe (Kandola, 1995). Roberson and Kulik (2007: 24) highlight that these trends were initially 'heralded as an opportunity for organizations to become more creative, to reach previously untapped markets, and in general to achieve and maintain a competitive advantage'. The key aim of diversity management was presented as beneficial for companies: profiting from demographic trends by gaining competitive advantage in using the talents of the new diverse workforce (Tatli, 2011).OK, thank

The concern with changing demographic trends prevails. Most notable trends worldwide currently are the ageing population; increasing female workforce representation; the requirements of millennial and Gen Z workers; and the continuing importance of migration; especially as European economies are ever more dependent on high-skilled jobs (Bossavie et al., 2022). Many older workers desire greater flexibility and more autonomy, so there will be a higher demand for part-time work and self-employment (CIPD, 2022). Additionally, this inter-generational workforce has varying views on job satisfaction, organisational commitment and willingness to quit, which provides challenges for businesses in effectively managing their workforces (Benson and Brown, 2011). With higher female workforce participation, due partially to changes made to women's State Pension age, more than two-thirds (71.6%) of women aged 16–64 were employed in the UK in February – April 2024, almost the highest since records began in 1971

(ONS, 2024). Moreover, professional women in increasing numbers wish to return to work following career breaks. This leads to a different set of issues that have not previously been considered. For example, Atkinson et al., (2021) are mindful that issues related to menopause in the workplace is lacking in both HRM research and HR policy and practice. The authors state that while organisational menopause policies are gradually being introduced, they may be hindered by line manager discomfort or resistance. HRM scholars and practitioners should be concerned with issues related to the menopause, given their implications for inclusion, workforce performance and retention. A further consideration is the changing role of men. Fathers, especially those of the millennial generation, increasingly want to spend more time caring for their children (TUC, 2017). Most younger fathers (68%) say that they would consider their childcare needs before taking a new job or promotion (Working Families, 2018). For these groups, there is a greater need for more flexible working patterns. Finally, the challenges of managing the increasing number of international migrants are starting to be addressed in the HR literature (Crowley-Henry and Al Ariss, 2018; Guo et al., 2020; Shirmohammadi et al., 2019) in terms of aligning the competences, skills and qualifications acquired in their home country to those of their host country. Hence, these demographic indicators signify the need to include and value those traditionally excluded or not particularly visible into the workforce.

A Business Case for Equal Opportunities and Managing Diversity

The business case for managing diversity initiatives focuses on the business benefits that employers accrue through making the most of the skills and potential of all employees. Consequently, the business case is fundamentally linked to the principles of strategic HRM: the human resource and its full utilisation are viewed as providing competitive edge (Storey, 1995). Additionally, it is crucial that equal opportunities initiatives tie in with the overall strategic organisational direction. A business case positions achieving equality as essential to achieving organisational goals. The effective management of diversity has many advantages, including a potentially improved corporate image with employees and customers and the generation of new business ideas and markets from the representation of a diverse workforce (Kele and Cassell, 2023). Moreover, it offsets business costs, such as the costs associated with the inefficient use of human resources, such as high staff turnover; low productivity; and access to a restricted pool of talent. These costs and benefits are linked to the demographic trends outlined earlier. The business case has blossomed as a rationale for the effective management of diversity and inclusion (D&I) within the workplace and is an important, underpinning argument for furthering equality at work. For instance, notwithstanding the changes to the labour market, the nature of work and the shift to increased work from home caused by the Covid-19 pandemic, 65% of UK parents felt increased loyalty to their employers when offered flexible working arrangements (Working Families, 2022).

General Principles and Activities

Diversity management is a process intended to create and maintain a positive work environment where the similarities and differences of individuals are valued, so that all can reach their potential and maximise their contributions to an organisation's strategic goals and objectives (Patrick

and Kumar, 2012). Pitts (2006) conceptualises diversity management as three inter-related components: recruitment and outreach, valuing differences, and pragmatic programmes and policies. Recruitment and outreach focus on organisations seeking out a range of different types of employees, such as strategically targeting typically under-represented groups (Pitts et al., 2010). The rationale is that greater staff diversity will lead to access to a wider range of talent and ideas, plus access to potentially novel markets. The second component identified by Pitts (2006) is valuing differences. Exponents of the management of diversity perspective (Cox, 1992; Jackson and Associates, 1992; Kandola and Fullerton, 1998; Thomas, 1990) argue that all differences must be valued, including those of white males. As such, Kandola and Fullerton provide a useful working definition of managing diversity:

> The basic concept of managing diversity accepts that the workforce consists of a diverse population of people. The diversity consists of visible and non-visible differences which will include factors such as sex, age, background, race, disability, personality and work style. It is founded on the premise that harnessing these differences will create a productive environment in which everybody feels valued, where their talents are being fully utilized and in which organizational goals are met (1998: 8).

Consideration of organisational diversity policies highlight some of the differences that need to be valued and managed. A typical policy will include differences, such as gender, race, disability, spent criminal convictions, sexual orientation, religion and beliefs, socioeconomic background, age and potentially others, such as personality differences and working styles. The third part of Pitts' (2006) model is pragmatic programmes and policies. These consist of a 'strategic set of management tools' (Pitts et al., 2010: 870) that enable diverse groups to have their needs met. These could, for example, include family-friendly policies for those with dependents, or policies that enable religious minorities to worship in the workplace.

In her review of the literature, Sabharwal (2014) states that there is an impetus for diversity management to shift from a passive (valuing diversity) to an active (diversity management) approach. This new approach should include mentoring programs, succession planning, family-friendly programs, alternative work arrangements, training, and accountability.

A Move to Inclusion

There are clear similarities between the ways in which scholars have branded inclusion as theoretically distinct from managing diversity, and diversity as distinct from equality (Oswick and Noon, 2014). Inclusion ensures that employees feel a sense of belongingness and uniqueness within a safe and nurturing workplace (Shore et al., 2018). Inclusive businesses ensure that all employees feel valued and feel safe to voice their opinions, express themselves and be heard and respected (Nishii, 2013). There is growing scholarship to suggest that an inclusive workplace results in positive outcomes, such as increased job satisfaction, retention, organisational commitment, trust, well-being, creativity, and innovation (Shore et al., 2018), while decreasing conflict, intention to leave, stress, job withdrawal, and turnover (Nishii, 2013). We can expect the inclusion discourse to continue growing in popularity, in line with its conceptual distancing from diversity and the decline in the diversity discourse (Oswick and Noon, 2014).

A focus on inclusion encompasses all types of difference. For example, an emerging challenge for managers is how best to handle neurodiversity in the workforce and what kind of reasonable adjustments are necessary (Austin and Pisano, 2017). Neurodiverse employees tend to exhibit behaviours associated with: dyslexia, dyspraxia, Tourette's syndrome, ADHD and ASD; conditions covered by the Equality Act 2010 and conditions associated with high levels of employment exclusion (Richards et al., 2019). However, such conditions enable different ways of creative thinking and may enhance productivity and innovation (Austin and Pisano, 2017).

Another fundamental change in recent years has been increased awareness of gender diversity, with the language, labels, and conversations around gender identity becoming increasingly broad and evolving beyond the traditional binary genders of women and men (Gustafsson Sendén et al., 2021). As such, some organisations have decided to encourage their staff to state their preferred pronouns, for instance, on email signatures, or added to name badges, to demonstrate allyship and support for all LGBTQIA+ (lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer/questioning, intersex, asexual/aromantic and more) people. It is important that companies are better informed about gender and gender diversity, so they can support and empower their employees, as well as meet their legal responsibilities.

Box 11.1 Pause for Reflection

Having just read the previous sections, how do you think equality, diversity and inclusion strategies work in your own organisation? Is it the case that all diverse groups feel included? Or do you think there is more work to do?

Implementing Diversity Initiatives

Given the range of different objectives that HR professionals seek to achieve through effective diversity management (Shen et al., 2009), many varied projects can be subsumed under diversity initiatives. Diversity management may therefore be viewed as any process, organisational system or practice that creates value from diversity and is formally implemented (Yang and Konrad, 2011). Some are designed to encourage the voices of all individuals to be heard, for example, advisory councils made up of different groups that can report to top management, and the creation of support groups for under-represented people, such as women's or cultural minorities' networks.

Box 11.2 HRM in Practice

Gender Transition Guides

In 2008, the German multinational software company, SAP, developed the Gender Transition Guidelines to assist transgender employees, their managers, colleagues and additional business partners such as HR through the gender transition process. They also inform SAP employees of concepts related to gender identity and expression. As of 2020, SAP has been using the Gender Transition Guidelines to support colleagues in countries such as Germany, the US, Brazil, the Philippines and Australia. SAP has been recognised as a top global employer for LGBTQIA+ inclusion by organisations such as Stonewall and Workplace Pride (ERT, 2020).

Employee networks can raise key issues associated with the lived experiences of particular diverse groups that can then be addressed more generally at company level. Other initiatives include the career development of minorities, such as fast-track development programmes for targeted groups, or rewarding managers based on their record of developing those from targeted groups (CIPD, 2017). Many companies now outline their D&I policies on their websites, with examples of their D&I interventions.

A key element in most interventions is some form of diversity training. This usually focuses on the importance of successful diversity management for achieving business benefits and highlights how stereotypes of different groups may hinder their opportunities in the workplace. It also seeks to enable the integration of minority groups into the workforce and provide other workers with the skills to be able to work productively alongside the members of such groups (Pendry et al., 2007: 28). Successful organisational diversity training should have strong ethical and moral foundations, so that employees are more likely to consider diversity issues at work as ethical decisions (Jones et al., 2013). Moreover, it is proposed that embedding tolerance – acceptance of other points of view even when they differ from one's own, and proactive, common-ground-seeking dialogue with others – into the diversity training model is effective in overcoming the barriers to learning (Gebert et al., 2017).

Increasingly common is unconscious bias training, a recognition that we are all biased in different ways. The aim of the training is to recognise those biases so they can be acted upon.

Box 11.3 HRM in Practice

Unconscious Bias Testing

The Royal Bank of Scotland (RBS) undertook unconscious bias testing (across the UK and internationally) in 2014 around disability, sexual orientation, age, ethnicity and gender leadership to understand how unconscious bias was affecting the organisation and what training could be introduced. A tailored programme comprised a workshop for senior leaders, a webinar for those with managerial responsibilities, and scenario-based e-learning for all employees. RBS suggest they are now building a stronger pipeline of BAME individuals, improving recruitment and performance management/promotion processes and creating an environment where employees feel they can be themselves.

Yet, the effectiveness of conventional unconscious bias training is disputed. Rather, successful unconscious bias training teaches attendees to manage their biases, change behaviours, and track progress over time, as well as entailing structural changes to policies and operations, such as reviewing hiring processes and introducing incentives for improving diversity (Gino and Coffman, 2021).

International and Cultural Contexts: Managing Diversity Globally

Research examining how diversity initiatives are being implemented internationally indicates that much depends upon the cultural and historical context (Klarsfeld et al., 2022; Schwabenland and Tomlinson, 2015). Although diversity management practices developed in the Global

North, companies in the Global South often adopt the same practices without adequate consideration of important contextual differences (Hennekam et al., 2017). In their study of Nigerian banks, Umeh et al., (2023) outline that rather than 'watered down' westernised, decontextualised ideas of diversity, organisations operating in developing countries should adopt D&I policies and practices which retain core universal values of equality and diversity yet are contextualised and sensitive to ethnocultural values and beliefs, specific to ethnically diverse settings.

Bader et al., (2022) suggest that we know little about how multinational enterprises (MNEs) respond to the increasingly globalised nature of their workforce and operations. The extent to which diversity policies focusing on managing difference translate neatly across borders has also been questioned. Fernando (2021) critiques the colonial undertones and heightened power differentials of the expectation that non-Western subsidiaries will embrace diversity practices transferred from Western parent companies in a 'top-down' manner. Other challenges about whether a US or Western model of equality law and diversity is appropriate have been posed regarding India (Kundu and Mor, 2017), Australia (Ali and French, 2019) and New Zealand (Ghauri et al., 2021). Rao (2012), for instance, highlights how religion is one of the key facets of diversity within the Indian context but most firms do not record the religious affiliations of their staff.

Other research has considered inclusion in different international contexts. Tang et al. (2015) state that the word inclusion has had a long history in China, with its root firmly in traditional Chinese culture. However, inclusion has an additional meaning in China of openness and tolerance, but also being generous to the point of being magnanimous. In their research on inclusive management practices in China, they highlight how various inclusion practices are similar to those in the West, but that tolerance is unique to the Chinese context, where there is an emphasis on forgiving mistakes. Cooke and Saini (2012) argue that the Western definition of diversity is much broader than that found in China and India. Within India, caste, religion and gender are considered the most important sources of diversity, with Haq (2012) highlighting that the Indian constitution includes a range of protected groups, for example, scheduled caste and tribes. However, Bhattacharya et al., (2022) note that the caste system is so powerful that mandatory quotas to increase board gender diversity in Indian corporates appear to have no impact: homophily based hiring means that newly hired female directors tend to belong to the same privileged caste or community as existing directors; ensuring the maintenance of societal inequalities.

In South Korea, where diversity management is in its relatively early stages, in their survey of 177 companies, Mehng et al., (2019) found that given the high collectivist, high power distance culture which contributes to a gender hierarchical society that privileges men over women, increased gender workforce diversity generally negatively impacts organisational performance.

So, within different international contexts there are still differences, both within and between organisations. A complicating issue is the impact of increased globalisation, with difficulties in "root[ing] the diversity management concept outside Anglophone countries" (Meriläinen et al., 2009: 231). Individual companies may develop their own approach to diversity, but these approaches may be inappropriate within the different locations where a company is based. A pertinent example of these complexities is the HRM challenges facing MNEs in advancing LGBTQIA+ inclusion in countries where being gay is illegal, such as Malaysia or Jamaica, or even punishable by death, such as Uganda and Saudi Arabia (EY, 2019b). Global diversity management therefore has increasingly become a key challenge.

Fernando (2021) outlines a five-step approach in transferring diversity management agendas across global operating units. Firstly, MNEs must involve representative employees (from all levels) from their subsidiaries during the process, so that subsidiaries are considered equal partners.

Secondly, being mindful of the content and communication of the diversity message and how different employees may interpret and experience the message. Thirdly, informal group discussions in subsidiaries should take place to understand people's views and frustrations about diversity management. Fourth, to avoid stereotyping, everyone involved in delivering the diversity agenda needs to reflect and question their biases. Finally, consideration of the credibility of those communicating the diversity message.

Similarly, in their study of 20 HR/diversity managers working for MNEs in 9 different countries in the Middle East and North Africa, Hennekam et al., (2017) found that challenges in implementing diversity management strategies arise either when imposing a Western approach upon the local country, or forcing a reframing strategy where existing policies are reformulated to fit the Western requirements. Findings show that a sensitive approach is essential, whereby thought is given to the local context. In conclusion, MNEs need to revise diversity policies considering local multilevel considerations in the country in which they operate (Hennekam et al., 2017; Umeh et al., 2023).

Do Diversity Initiatives Deliver?

A key question about managing diversity initiatives is to what extent they work. One core issue is that many of the case studies in the literature do not contain any evaluative element. Jones et al., (2000) point out the paradox that as managing diversity develops as a worldwide vocabulary for examining or celebrating difference, US cultural dominance may be reinforced by a US model of difference being applied globally. Most definitions in the literature tend to study and conceptualise diversity categories as independent phenomena, unaffected by temporal and geographic context. As a result, many studies on diversity adopt a 'false sense of universalism', which overlooks the constantly changing nature of inequalities and power relations (Tatli and Özbilgin, 2012: 182).

Nevertheless, some organisations claim considerable business benefits from their engagement with the business case for D&I, which is now stronger than ever. For example, in their research at McKinsey & Co, of over 1,000 large companies across 15 countries, Dixon-Fyle et al., (2020) highlight that the most diverse companies, with highly gender- and ethically- diverse executive teams, outperform their least-diverse competitors in terms of profitability: outperforming by 25% and 36% respectively. Conversely, EY Ireland (2019) found that while all the 150 companies surveyed agreed that an inclusive environment is vital for business performance, only 26% have a specific programme in place to develop diverse leadership (a decrease of 6.7% since 2018) and almost 63% have not completed an organisational D&I diagnostic. In this instance, although the business benefits and societal justifications for hiring a diverse workforce form the central tenants of the diversity management literature, less consideration is attributed to the implementation of diversity management, leading to ambiguity and discrepancies in its application (Schwabenland and Tomlinson, 2015).

Research has also considered the impact of a positive climate for diversity in an organisation on a range of business outcomes. For example, Shen et al. (2010) considered the effects of diversity management on organisational citizenship behaviours in China. The authors indicate that the key diversity issue in China is household registration status, which differentiates rural peasants from urbanites, where rural peasants previously were forbidden from working in urban areas. Their results suggest that when effective diversity management practices in place, particularly in relation to selection and compensation, there is a greater likelihood in engagement in organisation citizenship behaviours from employees.

Moreover, the role of leaders is important in ensuring that D&I initiatives are successful. Research by Deloitte Australia shows that inclusive leadership behaviours can increase employees' feelings of inclusion by 70%, which subsequently translates into an increase in perceived team performance (+17 %), decision-making quality (+20%), and collaboration (+29%) (Bourke and Dillon, 2018). However, evaluating the success of such initiatives is difficult, as diversity management remains an ambiguous concept, with varying definitions and theoretical perspectives, and may be interpreted and therefore implemented differently across companies (Tasheva and Hillman, 2019).

Critiquing Diversity Initiatives

Beyond the effectiveness of diversity initiatives, several other critiques have emerged about the managing diversity approach. One concern is that managing diversity initiatives is just another management fashion. Prasad et al. (2011), in their case studies of the design and implementation of diversity management programmes in six Canadian organisations, highlight a high level of fashion consciousness among those who supplied diversity programmes and those who consumed them. This creates numerous difficulties, for example, a lack of local relevance in the initiatives introduced and superficiality in programme design.

Given the increasing popularity of D&I, some businesses are criticised for 'jumping on the D&I bandwagon' to show that they are committed to doing what they can for this cause. Indeed, a recent misjudgement regards diversity came from the social media company Snap Inc., creator of the mobile phone messaging app Snapchat, who had to apologise for their offensive filters, including a Bob Marley-themed filter and an anime-themed filter in 2016, as well as a controversial Juneteenth filter in 2020 (Ritschel, 2020). This shows a general lack of understanding and awareness of diversity and inclusion.

Additionally, the bandwagon effect may lead to resistance from employees. As with any change initiative, we would expect some resistance to managing diversity programmes. Yet, this resistance is rarely addressed within the literature as managing diversity is promoted as being in the interest of all groups, regardless of their differences. Wahl and Holgersson (2003) provide evidence of male managers' reactions to gender diversity activities in Sweden. They argue that several factors impact on those reactions, including the numerical gender distribution, and the nature of job segregation in the companies concerned. Indeed, Tang et al., (2015) suggest that the recent change in discourse from diversity to one of inclusion is recognition of the potential hostility that may emerge from those who do not see themselves as benefiting from diversity policies. Clearly, further consideration is needed of the issue of resistance, why it occurs and how it can be effectively managed, together with the consequences of that resistance for those traditionally disadvantaged groups who may be seen to gain from diversity initiatives.

To further complicate matters, diversity may also be engulfed as part of discussion on equality; with scholars arguing whether the two concepts are complementary or distinct (Kumra and Manfredi, 2012). However, with the increasing significance of legislation in determining labour market policies, it may be difficult to truly detach managing diversity in the workplace from the delivery of equal employment opportunities (Dickens, 1999). Thus, it appears that this shift to diversity management is only fractional: whilst 'equal opportunities' have been repackaged and rebranded into 'diversity management', this has not been accompanied by 'a shift in total mindset, values and norms in the field, which in turn would have shifted the practice' (Tatli, 2011: 246).

Another important issue to consider is the extent to which the business case for managing diversity is based is sustainable in the long term, in that it is only persuasive within a given

economic climate. For example, in times of national austerity, employing diverse groups may not be considered a business priority. Additionally, from their case studies of diversity practices in organisations, Michielsens et al. (2014) conclude that the prioritisation of other business objectives can restrict a company's ability to facilitate greater diversity.

A further concern is that the links between valuing diverse skills and business success can be problematic. For example, Walters (2016) in her analysis of the discriminatory recruitment 'look policy' of the fashion brand *Abercrombie & Fitch*, outlines how managers preferred staff with lighter skin tones to work with customers, while workers with darker skin tones were placed in stockroom roles, reinforcing colourist discrimination. While image is considered important for organisational success, with scholars investigating the business benefit of aesthetic labourers who 'look good and sound right' (Witz et al., 2003), in the above case, it could be argued, therefore, that engaging in discriminatory 'lookism' behaviours, based on appearance (Nickson et al., 2012), proved to be profitable; hence, drawing attention to some of the dilemmas that emerge when focusing upon a business case for equality alone. The problem is that this business case dominance over social equality arguments may lead to diversity management becoming a limited, selective, and ad-hoc practice (Heres and Benschop, 2010), whereby initiatives are mainly targeted at groups which allow for short-term direct organisational benefits and neglects those with less-easily quantifiable business gains (Dickens, 1999). This overlooks important social justice diversity rationales (Oswick and Noon, 2014).

A final point is that the business case may not apply equally to all diverse groups, with some groups fitting a business case more neatly than others. Woodhams and Danieli (2000) state that there is little about the business case for employing disabled people in the diversity literature. They suggest that, as a considerably heterogeneous group who are not segregated within the labour market, a managing diversity approach based on the identification of group-based characteristics has little to offer. Additionally, Fleischer and Zames (2011) argue that although the number of people with invisible disabilities – disabilities that are not immediately obvious, such as mental health conditions or neurodivergences – is larger than those with visible disabilities, they too are under-represented in research.

Indeed, social identity categories, such as disabilities or religion, may be either observable and/or more hidden depending upon the preferences, choices and/or constraints of the individual themselves. Moral, social, legal, and political disputes contiguous to these traits may also attract further attention, depending on context. For instance, a report by the UK charity Unlock (2020) highlighted the unique stigma that ex-offenders face due to their criminal convictions. Yet, only recently has research on this group in the managing diversity literature started to emerge, so fundamental societal changes for this group are limited.

Box 11.4 HRM in Practice

Supporting Homeless People

Veolia is a large UK environmental services company, providing waste and recycling, and water and energy services. Sustainability is core to the firm's vision and the company engages in numerous community outreach programmes. As part of its contract with Westminster Council, it set up a 'Road to Work' scheme, whereby homeless people and rough sleepers are given the opportunity to join Westminster's street cleaning team. It also provides several other programmes to support under-represented and disadvantaged groups, such as ex-offenders, the long-term unemployed and veterans into work.

For more information, see CIPD (2022)

This case example from Veolia highlights the complicated nature of the processes through which issues of power, fairness and equality are reformulated into issues of competitive advantage. The business-community outreach charity, Business in the Community (BITC) (2023) therefore calls on employers to support the 'Ban the Box' campaign: to create a fair opportunity for people with criminal convictions by removing the tick box from application forms. A recent governmental study reveals that 86% of employers of ex-offenders rate them as good at their job, with 92% of employers saying diverse recruitment has enhanced their reputation, helping them win new contracts (HM Prison and Probation Service, 2023).

Box 11.5 Pause for Reflection

Having just read about the successful Veolia case, to what extent do you think that an increased take-up of the BITC 'Ban the Box' campaign by other organisations could lead to wider effective societal change for ex-offenders?

Some of these challenges have been highlighted by the application of new theoretical approaches to the field, for example intersectionality. Formed through Black feminist thought and activism and an original focus on the symbiotic relationship between gender and race (Crenshaw, 1989), intersectionality emerged as a new theoretical framework through which to better understand the lived experiences of those with multiple disadvantaged demographic identities (e.g., Black, female, gay, Muslim) (Delgado and Stefancic, 2017; Hill Collins and Bilge, 2016). An intersectional approach has been advocated to build inclusion, yet there are challenges to both researchers and practitioners in putting this concept into practice (Hall et al., 2019). This is because of the complexity resulting from the simultaneous interaction of identity categories with each another and with wider societal and power structures, which create experiences of oppression and privilege unique to everyone (Crenshaw, 1991; Hill Collins, 2015). For instance, an undocumented migrant woman of colour in the UK will have qualitatively different experiences from her white neighbour who holds British citizenship. An intersectional approach thereby emphasises that an individual's particular experiences of discrimination are the result of multiple oppressions, which are structural, rather than individual. While many of the procedures we have for fighting discrimination in the UK, such as the Equality Act 2010, confront each element in isolation (e.g., sexism, racism, ageism), intersectionality shows us that identities and experiences do not fit into such precise categories, and nor do transformative solutions.

Conclusion

Managing diversity and inclusion is a live and important issue in the international workplace. Indeed, the #MeToo and #BlackLivesMatter movements highlighted how the issues reviewed in this chapter are increasingly discussed in the press and popular culture. Discrimination of particular groups based on a given set of characteristics is no longer seen as acceptable business practice and may have a negative reputational impact. From an academic perspective, there is clearly the need for more research to evaluate the impact of diversity initiatives. Ideally, research should focus on the longitudinal assessment of diversity programmes, using a range of criteria from impact on economic performance to the attitudes of those groups that the interventions have been designed to address. Additionally, as stated earlier, there is a need to consider the

various levels of analysis and characteristics where discrimination can occur. Only then can the claims made for the success of managing diversity approaches be properly evaluated.

A further key question is the problematic nature of universalistic notions of managing diversity. In practice, the term does not have a unitary meaning; it means different things to different people, as well as in different cultures or organisations in various international settings. Increasingly, there are challenges from other cultures about whether the Western model is appropriate. This is particularly important regarding the development of global diversity initiatives and questions the international application of locally derived diversity policies. Furthermore, context is always important. It is evident that, at certain times, some groups may experience a rise in discriminatory actions, as evidenced in Kaifi's (2009) account of the experiences of Afghan Americans post-9/11. There is also emerging literature about the experiences of international migrants, and the challenges they and organisations face in integrating into the workforce (e.g., Guo et al., 2020). Additionally, a concern linked to technological advances has been gender bias recorded in machine learning and artificial intelligence (AI), with Google introducing gender-specific translations in its software and programming in December 2018 to avoid creating or reinforcing unfair biases (Johnson, 2020).

Finally, we can see that inclusion is becoming more of a term of popular usage within the diversity management literature, yet is still in its infancy, with no common definition. Additionally, Shore et al., (2018) suggest that there is a move from diversity to inclusion within the practitioner literature, to improve the experiences of those historically marginalised groups in the workplace. However, there is a disparity amongst researchers about whether inclusion represents something new or different from managing diversity. Winters (2014: 206) notes 'perhaps the most salient distinction between diversity and inclusion is that diversity can be mandated and legislated, while inclusion stems from voluntary actions.' More impetus is therefore needed to further equity and equality for those traditionally marginalised groups within the workforce and those where new forms of pernicious discrimination are emerging. What managing diversity approaches do highlight is the economic costs to organisations of losing talented staff through discriminatory practices, which is a crucial issue for HRM policy and practice.

Case study 11.1 RB Technology

Juliet Kele

Launched in 2011, RB Technology (RBT) is one of the fastest growing software companies in Tanzania. Based in Tanzania's largest city and financial hub, Dar Es Salaam, RBT employs 70 specialists, with expertise in custom software development and web development systems. Given their experience and customer-focused approach, they have developed a first-class reputation and are trusted by clients across Tanzania. However, over the last decade, the information technology sector has been booming in Tanzania, with the emergence of many new companies providing software development services in recent years – increased competition for RBT. As such, the CEO of RBT, Rashid Bakari, wishes to expand the services of the business further to assist more start-up firms, as part of its mission to become among the best and most affordable software development companies in Tanzania.

Regarding recruitment practices at RBT, most job adverts are placed internally in the firm, as the ideal of 'home-grown talent' (entry-level employees working their way up in the firm to reach senior roles) is a source of pride. Rashid feels that keeping talented employees is seen as sustaining organisational competitive advantage. However, internal recruitment and promotion will not be sufficient

here, given the desire to expand the business. Rashid thus decides that a large external recruitment drive is needed, to bring in the most talented individuals who will work together to design and develop tech solutions to fit the unique requirements of these start-ups. Rashid wishes to direct his recruitment strategy with a focus on hiring more women as well as younger talent to better fit the image desired by clients in this new market. Although the Government of Tanzania has adopted policies to advance both gender equality and youth inclusion at work. Rashid knows that recruiting from a diverse talent pool may pose a challenge, given the employment problems in Tanzania of a skills mismatch between formal education and job market requirements, resulting in high unemployment rates among younger people.

Rashid calls his friend, Elizabeth, who is a HR manager at one of the largest banks in Dar Es Salaam, for recruitment advice. Elizabeth states that the Bank recently embarked on a 'women in leadership' programme, in a bid to achieve greater gender balance at leadership level. Elizabeth informs Rashid that, according to Tanzania's Employment and Labour Relations, the 2007 Rules state that businesses can utilise affirmative action measures to promote equality or the elimination of discrimination in the workplace. 'What about quotas?' she asks. This is one of the ways, she said, in which the Bank was able to achieve a greater leadership gender balance.

Rashid reflects on this advice. He wishes to promote equal opportunity in employment and strives to eliminate discrimination by implementing good employment policies. Would quotas be the answer to tap into this new and lucrative start-up market? He is also mindful of his rising business costs, so wishes to keep recruitment costs down if possible. Reviewing the current recruitment practices of RBT, Rashid finds that there is only an equal opportunities policy to support diversity management. Potential applicants are judged on merit: on their previous experience of successfully designing solutions to technical problems.

Later, after speaking with a customer-services manager, Rashid realises that the promotion process was more informal than he previously thought, especially with vacancies at senior level. While an internal email is sent out to all staff inviting applications each time there is a promotion round, the preferred method of recruitment for most managers is using personal recommendations. This method was considered desirable, especially when recruiting for individuals to join a small team for a particular series of tech projects. Rashid had also heard rumours about some employees being offered monetary rewards following successful recommendations. The customer-services manager admits, given the size of RBT, there is less room to 'carry any passengers or any problems', so the preferred route is to ask someone you know.

Rashid heads back to his office, reflecting on these conversations. He feels that word-of-mouth recruitment, while inexpensive, does little to change the likelihood of hiring applicants from diverse backgrounds. He is considering using quotas, yet he feels that this would impose diversity management practices at RBT, rather than authentically facilitating progress. Rather, he wonders whether using social media for recruitment to raise the profile of the firm would attract more younger applicants.

Questions

1 Outline the steps you would take as part of the company's recruitment strategy in relation to diversity management practices?
2 What interventions do you think might be useful to implement in this case?
3 What plans would you make for evaluating your proposed interventions?

Case Study 11.2 CMC retailing

Catherine Cassell

CMC is a global retailing organisation headquartered in California that buys and sells women's and men's fashion in retail outlets throughout the world. The company CEO, Caitlin Stephens, is one of the few female CEOs in the industry and is renowned for taking a pro-diversity stance and particularly for encouraging women to move to managerial positions in the company. Given her pro-female stance, she regularly features in the business pages and features sections of newspapers across the world, where CMC has retail outlets. Recently, the company has had a major reputational hit in that a group of female employees in Australia have accused the company of sex discrimination, arguing that women with children have been discriminated against and are being paid less than men. The high-profile case in an Australian court has also meant that Caitlin's life has been investigated in depth by journalists seeking to find more 'dirt' on CMC and its seemingly exemplary feminist CEO.

Caitlin wonders how her company could possibly have got into the situation where they could have been involved in such discriminatory processes. The company values of diversity and inclusion are taken very seriously, and all employees must go through some form of diversity training as part of their induction to ensure that these values are engendered into everyday practices. She is aware that in different cultural locations diversity needs to be addressed in different ways. For example, in a recent expansion of the company into the Chinese market, she has been keen to ensure that the values and commitment to diversity are promoted as being located within traditional Chinese notions of inclusion. She is aware that some policies do not easily translate. However, to be found guilty of discrimination in Australia presents her with a puzzle. Her Australian Director of Operations has suggested that the issue has arisen because of local management practices that will be dealt with but given the significance of the incident for both the company and her own personal reputation, Caitlin decides to visit the Australian head office to meet with key staff and discover more about why the incident has occurred.

At a meeting with the Australian Director, Matt Sparkes, Caitlin asks more about how such discriminatory practices can occur. Matt expands on his view that the crucial issue is local management. At all the retail outlets staff have the right to access work–life balance programmes that include flexible working. However, during the recent run up to Christmas, which is the busiest time of the year, Matt has been aware that different managers may be implementing these policies somewhat differently. Caitlin is committed to a no-blame culture, so is keen to discuss the issues and problems with the policies openly with the managers concerned. Hence, a random selection of local managers are collected together to meet with Caitlin for an open exchange of views about their experience of the policy.

During the discussion, several issues with flexible working become apparent. First, it is clear that the commitment to flexible work arrangements can be problematic for store managers. For example, one manager reported that they had had little direction from their regional line manager about how to deal with staff who wanted a variety of flexible working arrangements. Moreover, they felt under considerable pressure to keep these arrangements to a minimum because of the impact they had on the operation of the stores. The manager described how with a variety of women working different and flexible shifts, managing the operational needs of the business was an ongoing challenge. One female manager said that as a woman without children she felt that flexible working initiatives were often divisive and that she had to work hard to stop resentment towards women who worked flexibly in their department. In order to compensate some disgruntled male employees, she had offered them extra overtime, one of the causes of the discrimination case in another outlet.

A second issue that emerged was that different managers were interpreting the flexible working policies in different ways. As the busiest time of the year the pressures of managing staff working

patterns became even more challenging. In some cases, this would lead to individual managers making more informal arrangements with staff to discourage the uptake of more rigid, formal, flexible working policies. However, the informal nature of these arrangements led to accusations of favouritism from other staff. Caitlin was surprised to discover that rather than flexible working policies leading to a happier and more motivated workforce, in some cases they had instead led to resentment and a confrontational culture.

Caitlin realised that despite the efforts that had been made to instil values of diversity and inclusion throughout the company internationally, what was just as important was how managers operationalised those values in practice. She realised that more thinking was needed about CMC's diversity and inclusion policies. Therefore, she decided to institute a new diversity task force to evaluate the company's diversity and inclusion strategy with a view to ensuring that the positive company values are translated into practice. Her intention is that as well as evaluating the policy, the task force will produce a list of actions that will ensure that the company delivers on effective diversity management internationally.

Questions

Imagine you have been allocated the role of Chair of the new diversity and inclusion task force at CMC.

1 What steps would you take to evaluate the company's current diversity and inclusion strategy?
2 What interventions do you think might be useful in this case?
3 What plans would you make for evaluating your proposed interventions?

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